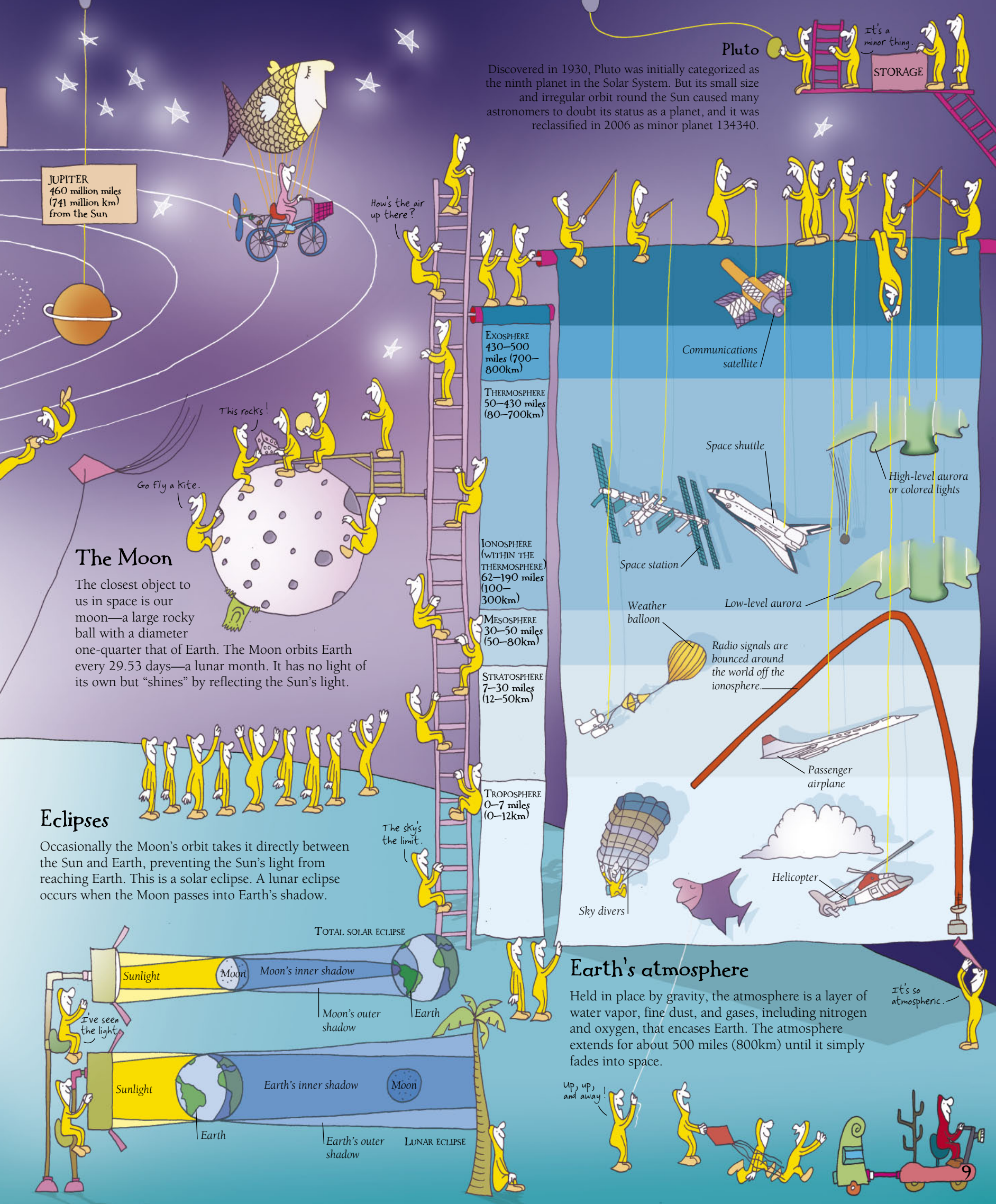


Discovered in 1930, Pluto was initially categorized as the ninth planet in the Solar System. But its small size and irregular orbit round the Sun caused many astronomers to doubt its status as a planet, and it was reclassified in 2006 as minor planet 134340.

Pluto



JUPITER
460 million miles
(741 million km)
from the Sun



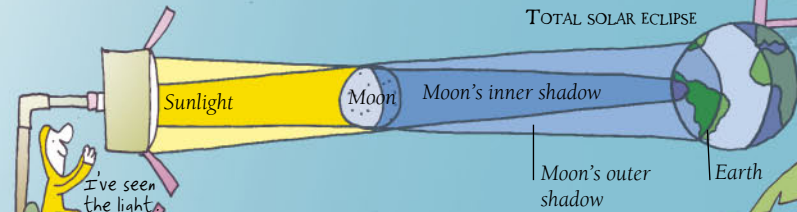
The Moon

The closest object to us in space is our moon—a large rocky ball with a diameter one-quarter that of Earth. The Moon orbits Earth every 29.53 days—a lunar month. It has no light of its own but “shines” by reflecting the Sun’s light.

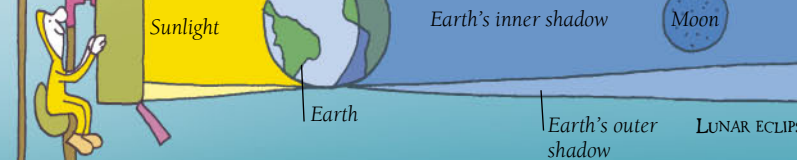
Eclipses

Occasionally the Moon’s orbit takes it directly between the Sun and Earth, preventing the Sun’s light from reaching Earth. This is a solar eclipse. A lunar eclipse occurs when the Moon passes into Earth’s shadow.

TOTAL SOLAR ECLIPSE



LUNAR ECLIPSE



Earth's atmosphere

Held in place by gravity, the atmosphere is a layer of water vapor, fine dust, and gases, including nitrogen and oxygen, that encases Earth. The atmosphere extends for about 500 miles (800km) until it simply fades into space.

It's so atmospheric.

Up, up, and away!